

A Priori vs A Posteriori Knowledge and Biblical Conscience

Question	Shorter Answer	Larger Answer
Q1. What is <i>a priori</i> knowledge?	Knowledge that can be known independently of experience, through reason alone.	<i>A priori</i> knowledge is that which is known through reason alone, without requiring empirical observation. It includes mathematical truths ($2 + 2 = 4$), logical principles (law of non-contradiction), and definitional truths ("All bachelors are unmarried"). This knowledge is universal, certain, and true by logical necessity.
Q2. What is <i>a posteriori</i> knowledge?	Knowledge that depends on empirical experience and observation of the world.	<i>A posteriori</i> knowledge depends on sensory evidence and empirical experience. It includes scientific facts ("Water boils at 100°C at sea level"), historical events ("The Civil War ended in 1865"), and observational claims ("The sky is blue"). This knowledge is contingent on how the world actually is and could potentially be false.
Q3. How can we remember the difference between <i>a priori</i> and <i>a posteriori</i> knowledge?	<i>A priori</i> = "prior to" experience; <i>a posteriori</i> = "after" experience.	The fundamental divide is this: Does this knowledge require going out and checking the world, or can I figure it out just by thinking? <i>A priori</i> means "Think it out" while <i>a posteriori</i> means "Check it out." The complexity of knowledge is not the issue—some <i>a priori</i> knowledge is quite difficult while some <i>a posteriori</i> knowledge seems obvious.
Q4. What does Scripture teach about conscience and moral knowledge?	God has written His law on human hearts, giving all people basic moral knowledge.	Romans 2:14-15 teaches that Gentiles "show that the requirements of the law are written on their hearts, their consciences also bearing witness." This means moral knowledge exists independently of external revelation or cultural learning. Basic moral intuitions appear across cultures without explicit teaching, suggesting built-in moral knowledge from God.

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Q5. Is biblical conscience <i>a priori</i> or <i>a posteriori</i> knowledge?	Biblical conscience operates primarily like <i>a priori</i> knowledge but can be influenced by experience.	Conscience functions like <i>a priori</i> knowledge in its universality, immediacy (we know murder is wrong without investigation), and rational foundation. However, it also has <i>a posteriori</i> elements since conscience can be "seared" (1 Tim. 4:2) or "defiled" (Titus 1:15) by experience, cultural variations exist in moral application, and conscience needs to be informed and can err.
Q6. What kind of knowledge did Adam and Eve possess before the Fall?	They possessed immediate, complete, God-given moral knowledge without needing to learn or reason.	Adam and Eve were created in "knowledge, righteousness, and holiness" (WSC 10) with no learning curve. Their knowledge was neither <i>a priori</i> (requiring reasoning) nor <i>a posteriori</i> (requiring experience) but rather direct divine impartation—archetypal knowledge that served as the original pattern for human moral understanding. They had perfect conscience with no tension between knowing and doing.
Q7. How did the Fall affect human knowledge?	The Fall darkened understanding and corrupted reasoning, but did not destroy moral knowledge entirely.	The Fall brought darkened understanding (Eph. 4:18), suppression of truth (Rom. 1:18), and corrupted reasoning about moral matters. However, residual moral knowledge remains—the "law written on hearts"—providing enough moral awareness for accountability. Our current moral knowledge through conscience or Scripture is an attempt to recover what Adam and Eve possessed immediately and perfectly.
Q8. What is the theological significance of natural moral knowledge?	It provides the basis for universal human dignity, moral accountability, and apologetic engagement.	Natural moral knowledge from conscience establishes that people without Scripture can still be held morally responsible before God. It provides a point of contact for Christian apologetics since people intuitively know right from wrong. It explains why moral concepts translate across cultures—there's a shared foundation of moral knowledge. The natural law tradition sees this as knowable through reason, supporting universal human dignity.

Question	Shorter Answer	Larger Answer
Q9. How should Christians view the role of experience in shaping conscience?	While conscience provides basic moral knowledge, it must be shaped and informed by Scripture and the Spirit.	Though conscience gives immediate moral knowledge, it can be corrupted by sin and needs refinement through Scripture and the Holy Spirit. Experience affects conscience both positively (through godly instruction) and negatively (through sin's influence). Christians must distinguish between knowing moral law (which conscience provides) and following it (which requires grace and spiritual transformation).
Q10. What practical applications flow from understanding biblical conscience?	It guides apologetics, missions, discipleship, and ethical reasoning in Christian life.	For apologetics: Natural moral knowledge provides common ground—people intuitively know right from wrong even without biblical revelation. For missions: Moral concepts translate across cultures because of God's imprint on all people. For discipleship: Our conscience must be continually shaped by Scripture rather than experience alone. For ethics: Some moral truths are discoverable through reason, not just divine command, though Scripture provides the clearest revelation.

Key Scripture References: Romans 2:14-15; 1 Timothy 4:2; Titus 1:15; Ephesians 4:18; Romans 1:18; Westminster Shorter Catechism Q10